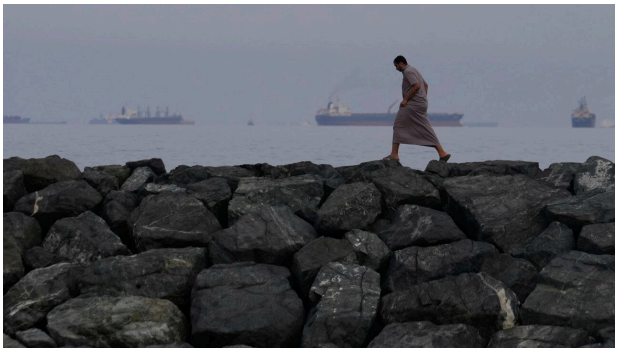
The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: AP

Donald Trump postponed attacks against **Iran's** power plants following what he called "productive conversations" with the regime. Iran's foreign ministry, however, denied any talks with America. On Saturday America's president gave Iran a 48-hour ultimatum to fully open the Strait of Hormuz, or else he would "obliterate" its energy infrastructure. Iran threatened to retaliate by sealing off the Strait and mining all sea routes into the Gulf.

Stockmarkets rose in response to Mr Trump's announcement, having earlier fallen sharply. In America the S&P 500 and the tech-heavy NASDAQ index both grew by more than 1.5%. In Europe the FTSE 100 and Stoxx 600 indices more than recovered their losses for the day. Meanwhile oil prices dropped: the price of the benchmark Brent crude fell by a tenth to around $100 a barrel.

Giorgia Meloni conceded defeat in a referendum on judicial reform. Italy's prime minister staked political capital on a proposal that her critics say would weaken the independence of courts, which she has deemed hostile to her right-wing government. Early results showed that 54% of Italians opposed Ms Meloni's plan. Nearly 59% of those eligible to vote turned out in the two-day referendum—more than expected.

Iran also threatened to destroy energy and water infrastructure in the Middle East and continued to attack the region. Saudi Arabia said it had shot down several Iranian drones. On Sunday at least seven people were injured in an Iranian missile attack on Tel Aviv; 180 were hurt in separate strikes on southern Israel on Saturday. Meanwhile more Israeli missiles hit **Tehran**, Iran's capital.

Danone struck a €1bn ($1.2bn) deal to buy **Huel**, a British meal-replacement drinks company. The French food giant wants to capitalise on the popularity of "functional" foods, which are modified to make them more nutritious. Huel's milkshake-style meals have been popular with users of weight-loss drugs who struggle to get enough nutrients, such as protein, when they start eating less.

Police in **Britain** launched an investigation into arson attacks on **Jewish volunteer ambulances** in north London. Four vehicles were set ablaze early on Monday. Officers said they were looking into claims of responsibility by a terrorist organisation. Britain's prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, called it a "horrific antisemitic attack", and officials said the government would replace the vehicles.

China's leader, Xi Jinping, reaffirmed his commitment to a futuristic city project known as **Xiongan**. Plans for the green, ultra-modern urban area 100km south of Beijing were unveiled in 2017, but building has moved slowly. Mr Xi had called for state-owned enterprises, universities and hospitals to transfer faster from the capital to the new location.

Figure of the day: $4bn, the value of venture-capital deals sealed in Africa in 2025, nearly quadruple the amount in 2020. We examine why the future of Africa will be shaped by investment rather than aid.

Photograph: AP

Infrastructure week in the Iran War

The fourth week of the American-Israeli war against Iran began with attacks on infrastructure, with the threat of more to come. On Saturday Donald Trump threatened to strike Iran's energy plants within 48 hours if its regime does not "fully open" the Strait of Hormuz, gateway to 20% of the world's oil supplies, to shipping.

This came after an exchange of missile hits and air-strikes between Israel and Iran which targeted crucial infrastructure in both countries. Shrapnel from an Iranian missile fell on Israel's main oil refinery in Haifa, causing fires. Iran also scored direct missile hits on the southern Israeli towns of Dimona and Arad, injuring more than 160 civilians. Israel's nuclear enrichment facility is nearby. Iran claimed to be retaliating to an Israeli air-strike on its Natanz reactor, and Israel had also hit one of Iran's largest gas-fields. The war has already caused a spike in global energy prices; much worse may be in store.

Photograph: Getty Images

Is private credit cracking?

Worries about private credit are intensifying. For months, funds that invest in unlisted debt have seen their clients attempting to withdraw money, despite the assets the funds hold being illiquid. They typically cope with this by imposing limits on how much cash investors can pull out. But the news in February that a retail fund run by Blue Owl had failed to honour its withdrawal terms has sparked panic. Investors are rushing to extract their capital even from funds run by giants like BlackRock.

It is unclear whether Blue Owl's fund was simply mismanaged or failed because of a structural flaw. In private, its peers point to the rush of money that flowed into it and similar funds in the months leading up to the jitters. They muse that the need to invest this quickly led to lax underwriting standards for loans that are likely to turn sour. Given the speed with which investors have funnelled capital into the wider private-credit market in recent years, that is a disturbing thought.

Photograph: Samuel Corum/Sipa USA

SCOTUS takes up postal balloting

On Monday, with the midterm elections less than eight months away, America's Supreme Court tackles a question that could change how votes are counted.

The dispute in *Watson v Republican National Committee* concerns Mississippi's law that allows mail-in ballots to be counted if postmarked by election day and received up to five business days later. Republicans challenge this grace period as a violation of 19th-century federal statutes that set "Tuesday next after the first Monday of November" as America's uniform election day.

Mississippi counters that elections are complete once "voters have marked and submitted their ballots". The RNC says "chaos and suspicions of impropriety" would ensue without a firm deadline. Mississippi warns that scrapping the leeway would "doom" the laws of nearly 30 states that count some ballots after election day, potentially disenfranchising many thousands of voters—particularly the elderly and disabled, as well as Democrats, who tend to rely more on postal voting.

Photograph: AFP

Russian setbacks in Ukraine

While all eyes are on the war against Iran, something significant appears to be happening in Ukraine. Russia has begun its spring offensive, carrying out large-scale attacks. But in the five days to Saturday, Russia reportedly sustained 7,850 casualties, suffering the highest losses on two of those days since the invasion in 2022. Russian attacks have become increasingly vulnerable to reorganised Ukrainian drone units. They allow Ukraine to inflict casualties on Russian forces without risking too much of its own scarce manpower.

Meanwhile, Ukraine is striking targets deep inside Russia. Since February, at least 110 missions have been carried out. On March 17th, one adviser to the Kremlin, Sergei Shoigu, warned that “no Russian region can feel safe”; even the Urals, where much of the war economy is based, is in “the immediate danger zone”. However, despite a meeting in Miami over the weekend between American and Ukrainian negotiating teams, the prospect of Russia entering into serious talks seems as remote as ever.

Photograph: Getty Images

Pakistan’s dire straits

Pakistan Day is supposed to be the appointed time when the country’s powerful military forces get to flex their muscles. The annual celebrations, to commemorate the adoption of its Islamic constitution in 1956, typically involve goose-stepping, missiles, tanks and an air show. This year’s events have been cancelled, though, as the country reels from surging oil and gas prices. A simple flag-hoisting will have to do.

Pakistan is among the countries most exposed to Iran’s closure of the Strait of Hormuz. With almost 90% of its oil and gas coming from the Middle East, large debts and scant foreign-exchange reserves, it is in a tight spot. Already, the government has closed schools and hiked petrol prices. To make matters worse Pakistan’s war with the Taliban in neighbouring Afghanistan is at risk of escalating after an airstrike hit a hospital in Kabul on March 16th. The country’s military leaders find themselves between Iran and a hard place.

Violent events*, Jan 1st 2026-Mar 13th 2026

Perpetrator: ○ Pakistani military ● Afghan military ○ TPP

*Battles, explosions/remote violence or violence against civilians Source: ACLED

300 km

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which album by Joni Mitchell, released in 1971, is often rated as one of the greatest of all time?

The more the state “plans” the more difficult planning becomes for the individual.

Friedrich Hayek